SENTAI

A cooperative card game for 2–4 players, 20–30 minutes. Nobody talks about their hand, and nobody ever draws. *Hold the line together.*

BY DARREN DON

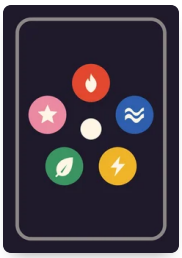


The goal. You are a squad of Heroes, each piloting a machine. Together, beat every monster the Boss sends, from Episode 1 to the Finale. Your hand is your health: nobody ever draws, and if any Hero's hand runs out, the whole squad loses.

Components



60 Hero cards
five colors, each 1–12



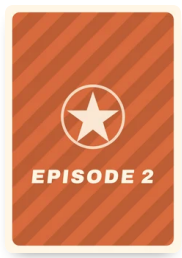
Hero back
the same on all 60



18 monsters
Emperor Gorvax's deck



18 heads
Vael, the Hydra's deck



Episode backs
Episode 1, 2 and the Finale



5 Hero powers
optional

Setup

1. Choose a Boss. **Emperor Gorvax** is the place to start. Sort his 18 cards into three decks by their backs: Episode 1, Episode 2 and the Finale.

2. Shuffle each episode's deck on its own and draw cards from it, face down, without looking. Return the rest to the box.

Heroes	Ep. 1	Ep. 2	Finale	Colors
2	3	3	4	3
3	3	4	5	4
4	4	4	4	5

3. Use **one more color than you have Heroes** (any colors). Shuffle those Hero cards and deal **15 to each Hero**. Any cards left over go back in the box, unseen.

4. Lay the Episode 1 monsters **face up in a line**, in the order drawn. The later episodes stay face down.

5. Pick a Hero at random to be the first **lead**.

Reading a Boss card

Every Boss card names a **combo** and prints its size three times: for 2, 3 and 4 Heroes (the dots). Use the number for your squad.

The four combos

Combo	Cards that fit
Run	Different ranks, any colors, that all fit in a row as long as the number. Gaps are fine while you build: a Run of 3 can hold a 5 and a 7, waiting for the 6.
Set	All the same rank.
Flush	All the same color, any ranks.
Roll Call	All different colors, any ranks, like the squad calling out one by one.

The first card played starts the combo, and every card after it has to fit with the cards already there.

No table talk. Never say or hint at what you hold, what you want played, or what you plan to do. Everything the squad learns comes from the cards.

A fight

Fight the monsters in the line one at a time, from the front.

1 Build the combo

Starting with the lead and going left, each Hero takes **one turn**: add **1 or 2 cards** that fit to the shared combo, face up, or pass. Stop as soon as the combo reaches the monster's number.



A Run of 3: a 4, a 5 and a 6, in any colors.

2 Beaten

If the combo is complete, the monster is beaten. Discard it and every card in the combo: those cards are spent.

3 Or missed

If everyone has had a turn and the combo is short, the monster holds on. Every card in the combo goes back to the Hero who played it, so everyone now knows who holds those cards. Then **every Hero discards 1 card** of their choice, face up.

4 Pass the lead

The lead passes to the left. After a miss, fight the **same monster again**. After a win, fight the next one in the line.

When the line is empty, the episode is over. Lay the next episode's monsters face up in a line and carry on.

Winning and losing

The squad wins by beating the last monster of the Finale.

The squad loses the moment any Hero has no cards in hand. You may never add your last card to a combo, so a hand only runs out by discarding.

What you know

You can see this episode's monsters, every card in the combo, every discard, and how many cards each Hero holds. When a combo falls short you also see exactly which cards go back to which Hero: remember them.

You never see the cards left in the box, your teammates' hands, or the monsters of the episodes to come.

Playing well

The lead's first card is a message: it picks the rank or the color, so lead something you think the others can follow. Adding a card to a combo that then falls short costs you nothing extra, because the card comes back. Holding back only saves cards when the squad would have won without you.

A missed monster never goes away. It costs the squad a card each and then has to be beaten anyway, so missing on purpose never helps.

Easier or harder. Add the Hero powers on the next page for an easier game. For a harder one, face Vael, the Hydra.

Questions

Do I have to add a card if I can? No. You may always pass.

Can a Run go around from 12 to 1? No. 12 is the highest rank and 1 the lowest.

Can a Roll Call be bigger than the colors in play? No card asks for that: the largest Roll Call is one card of every color.

May I look through the discards? Yes. Discards are face up and anyone may look at them at any time.

Vael, the Hydra

A harder Boss. Set up as usual with Vael's 18 cards, but deal **14 cards** to each Hero.

Grow **two heads** from the Episode 1 pile with 2 Heroes, or **three heads** with 3 or 4 Heroes, side by side and face up. The rest of each episode stays face down. Each head has a **hex**, in force from the moment the head appears until it is gone.

1. **A round**
   Starting with the lead, each Hero takes one turn: add **1 or 2 cards to one head**, or **1 card each to two heads**, or pass. Cards stay on a head from round to round.
2. **Cut**
   At the end of the round, a head whose combo is complete is cut off. Discard it and its cards.
3. **Enrage**
   An unfinished head that is upright turns sideways: it is **enraged**.
4. **Strike**
   An unfinished head that was already enraged **strikes**. Discard it and the cards on it, and every Hero discards **2 cards**.
5. **Grow**
   Fill each empty space with a new head from the current episode's pile, then the next episode's. Pass the lead to the left.

The squad wins when the last head is cut off or strikes, as long as every Hero still holds a card.

The hexes

Hex	While this head is out
Hunger	At the end of each round, the Hero with the most cards discards 1. On a tie, the tied Hero nearest the lead, going left.
Venom	If this head strikes, every Hero discards 1 more.
Coil	No Hero may add more than 1 card a turn to this head.
Split	You can't feed this head if the Hero just before you fed it.
Brood	When this head is enraged, it needs 1 more card.
Spite	When this head is cut, the Hero who added its last card discards 1.

Hero powers (optional)

Shuffle the five power cards and deal one to each Hero, face up.

Power	What it does
Command	Always on. When you lead, you may add up to 3 cards.
Riptide	Once a game. When the squad would discard, nobody does.
Overcharge	Once a game. One card you add fits the combo, whatever its rank and color.
Steady	Always on. Whenever the squad discards, you discard 1 fewer.
Beacon	Once an episode. On your turn, show one card from your hand to everyone.

Playing online? Sentai is playable in your browser at darrendon.com/games/sentai, with a tutorial, bot teammates, and online tables you can join with a five-letter code.